

Sword of the New World: Granado Espada

Of late, it appears the Ragnarok hype has fizzled down. Now I'm holding a DVD of *Sword of the New World*, an MMORPG that was launched around May; the person behind this project is the same guy who made *Ragnarok Online*.

Well, you start the game and there is this painful wait while it gets updated off the Internet... Once logged in, you create a character (like in every MMORPG or RPG out there). There are five races to choose from—Fighter, Musketeeer, Wizard, Scout, and Elemental, each with its own set of strengths and weaknesses.

(For those who aren't familiar with MMORPGs, they are multiplayer games played alongside thousands of players, completing one mission after another. Experience is gained when you kill monsters, which moves your character to the next level.)

Nothing really special there, but what's special is, you can create up to three different characters, and move all of them around the game maps while still having control over every character individually! There are plenty of quests and missions to keep you occupied for a long time.

It's fairly easy to level up, but some of the more powerful monsters can be a little difficult at times, and the lag doesn't help—so choose your monsters wisely.

All seemed to be going fairly well, but then came this monster camp. Get this—first you have crocodiles hopping around like kangaroos. Then you have roosters as large as the crocodiles. Just when you think you've seen

everything, some of them explode when killed, into a mango, which you pick up to regenerate health. Perfect! Just like in real life...

The character outfits are very well-made, and more importantly, unique; not cheesy like in most MMORPGs. The environments are simple but colourful and fresh.

We knew lag was going to be the major issue with MMORPG servers based far away from India, but it didn't feel all that bad, surprisingly. There is a slight delay of one to two seconds every time you execute a Move or Attack command, but nothing that really dampens the experience.

Unfortunately, you don't come across a lot of players in *Sword of the New World*—it's a very young community as of now.

This MMORPG is only getting started and can be a crowd-puller given the right amount of exposure. No Indian servers yet, so we'll have to do with the European and American ones. *Sword of the New World* goes far beyond *Ragnarok Online*, but it's going to be a tall order to knock over heavyweights like *World of Warcraft* and *Guild Wars*. Personally, I'm not very impressed—I don't see myself playing it for months together. Still, the game is fun—in a weird manner. It's an over-the-top experience *Ragnarok* fans will undoubtedly appreciate.

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Rating: 6/10
Developer: IMC Games
Publisher: K2 Networks
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